



Beyond the BOARDS

CBSE will scrap the Class X exam next year. Questions abound on its replacement, the oppressive Class XII exam and the way forward for other examination boards.

By Kaveree Bamzai

Last week, even as the Human Resource Development (HRD) Ministry announced that the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) was going to scrap the Class X examination for all plus two schools probably from next year, an 18-year-old jumped to death because she had scored 92 per cent in her school-leaving examination but failed to get into the college of her choice, Delhi's Lady Shri Ram. It's enough to send a chill down every parent's spine and welcome the CBSE's move, except that the larger purpose remains undone—to keep the Class XII exams distinct from the college admissions, to treat the former as a certification process and the latter as a selection test, and to reform a totally

oppressive examination system which has only encouraged the commercialisation of education.

The move also comes with its own confusing signals. Even as the CBSE works out the details of exactly what to replace the Class X exam with, it is also developing a proposal to grade schools which will only increase inequality, the kind that the scrapping of Class X exams hopes to achieve. There is also no talk as yet of any changes in the Class XII exam system which continues to suffer from a fear of subjectivity. As R. Govinda, acting vice-chancellor of the National University of Educational Planning and Administration (NUEPA), puts it, "The Class XII exam does not require a teacher to assess it. A clerk will do."

Currently, the CBSE, which sets the examination for 10,500 secondary

schools all over India (which is admittedly a fraction of the schools all over India), is working out the details of the comprehensive and continuous evaluation (CCE) system expected to replace the Class X exams. There is talk of modelling it on the lines of the portfolio assessment which assesses the overall development of the child—it will probably take the form of a card which will be a record book and grade the students' performance in academics and extra-curricular activities. It's in keeping with HRD Minister Kapil Sibal's grand vision of making education "child-centric" but it's a tall order given that even elite schools tend to have only physical education classes twice a week. There is also talk of a common college entrance exam. Indeed at the Central Advisory Board of Education meeting in Delhi last week, Sibal did some loud thinking on this when the issue of a common core maths and science curriculum for schools belonging to all examination boards came up. There is a possibility of a Scholastic Aptitude Test (SAT)-like examination on the lines of what is prevalent in the US. The school-leaving board can then focus on the capping of the school experience rather than try and be a filter for university entrance. If it tries to do both, it falls